

CO.3 Inspection Sequence

The up-to-four authorities that inspect one Colorado house, how the state electrical and plumbing inspections actually work, and a log for every one of them.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Colorado adopts no statewide residential building code: each county and each municipality decides for itself whether to require a building permit and which code edition to enforce, and a few counties require no building permit at all. Electrical and plumbing run on a separate, statewide track. Confirm every item with the office that will actually issue it before you rely on it. Where a local building permit exists, its permit card lists the inspections your job requires and it governs. The state trade inspections are additional to it, not part of it.

FOUR INSPECTORS, ONE HOUSE, NO COORDINATION

In a state with a single building department, one office schedules everything and one final closes the job. In Colorado your house can be inspected by four authorities under three statutes, and **none will tell the others what happened**. Nobody is managing your sequence. You are.

Who can inspect your house, and under whose authority

Inspector	What they look at	Whose office
Local building inspector	Footings through final, under whichever code edition your jurisdiction adopted — if it adopted one. Issues the certificate of occupancy where one exists.	Your county or municipality
Electrical inspector	Rough and final electrical against the National Electrical Code as adopted by the State Electrical Board. A state inspector unless your jurisdiction runs its own qualifying program.	State Electrical Board, or your local program
Plumbing / gas inspector	Plumbing and fuel gas piping against the Colorado Plumbing and Fuel Gas Codes. Decided separately from electrical — a jurisdiction may run one and not the other.	State Plumbing Board, or your local program
Public health (OWTS)	Site evaluation before the permit, and a final inspection of the installed system " <i>before the system is placed in use</i> " (25-10-106(1)(h)).	Your local public health agency

C.R.S. 12-115-120(2)(a); 12-155-120(1)(a); 25-10-106(1)(h); 30-28-205(1). A fifth party inspects in practice but not by law: your lender's draw inspector. Treat their checklist as a floor, not a code.

HOW A STATE INSPECTION ACTUALLY WORKS

Getting this wrong costs weeks. The Division sells the permit; it does **not** schedule the inspection. Its instruction is blunt: *"Do not contact the Division offices regarding inspection requests or scheduling. You must contact your inspector for scheduling information."* It publishes an inspection map and inspector contact list for each trade — find yours when you buy the permit, not the day you need them.

The state process, start to finish

Stage	What the rule is
The clock	A state inspector <i>"shall inspect ... within three working days after the receipt of the application for inspection"</i> — same words in both statutes (12-115-120(2)(b); 12-155-120(1)(b)). A real entitlement; hold them to it and plan your cover-up around it.
If it passes	The inspector <i>"shall issue a certificate of approval"</i> (12-115-120(3)(a); 12-155-120(2)(a)). Keep every one — they evidence that the work was inspected, which on the electrical side keeps your homeowner exemption alive.
If it fails	Written notice of disapproval with the reasons , a copy posted at the installation site and filed with the board (12-115-120(3)(b), (4)). If the installation is hazardous the inspector may order electrical service discontinued until it is made safe. After correcting, you <i>"shall apply for reinspection in the same manner as for the original inspection and pay the required reinspection fee."</i>
Who must be there	Board policy requires the contractor, or an adult homeowner or the homeowner's representative , to be present for the inspection of occupied dwelling units . A house under construction is not occupied — but confirm, and expect to meet them on a rural parcel they have never visited.

The finish line is the meter, not the final

On final inspection and approval *"notice shall be issued by the board to the utility,"* and **"A utility shall not provide service to any person required to have electrical inspection under this article 115 without proof of final approval"** (12-115-120(1)(b), (c)). Emergencies get at most seven days. Whatever else is or is not required where you are building, this is the gate: **no approved electrical final, no permanent power**. Schedule your electrical final with the utility's connection date in mind, not after it.

THE TYPICAL LADDER — AND WHERE THE STATE SLOTS IN

No Colorado statute enumerates residential inspections; your jurisdiction's adopted code and permit card do. The order below is the **typical** shape an IRC-based code produces, annotated with which authority owns each rung when the state runs the trades. Verify names and count against your own permit card.

Typical order — your permit card governs; authority varies by jurisdiction

Inspection	Whose	What must be complete
1. Footing / setback	LOCAL	Forms and steel in place before concrete; setbacks verified against the approved site plan.
2. Foundation wall / dampproofing	LOCAL	Before backfill. On expansive soils this is where the engineered foundation design gets checked against what was actually built.
3. Underground plumbing, then slab	STATE or local, then LOCAL	Under-slab drain, waste, and vent pressure-tested and inspected, then the slab inspected before the pour. Buy the plumbing permit long before this.
5. Rough electrical	STATE or local	Wiring complete and open. Book early: the three-working-day clock starts when the inspector receives your request.
6. Rough plumbing and gas piping	STATE or local	Often two separate permits and, in practice, two separate inspections. Fuel gas is its own code and its own application.
7. Rough mechanical / framing	LOCAL	Called only after the trade rough-ins pass — which means after the STATE inspections, on a schedule the local inspector does not control.
8. Insulation, air sealing, drywall	LOCAL	Against the adopted energy code; any blower-door or duct-leakage test lands here. Some jurisdictions also inspect drywall fastening before tape.
10. Trade finals	STATE or local	Electrical and plumbing/gas each final out and issue their own certificate of approval. The electrical final triggers the utility notice.
11. OWTS final	PUBLIC HEALTH	After installation, before the system is placed in use (25-10-106(1)(h)).
12. Building final / CO	LOCAL	Where a local building permit exists. Expect to hand over the trade certificates, the OWTS approval, and the address.

The sequencing trap this creates

The rough electrical and rough plumbing rungs are usually the state's; framing is your local inspector's, and it cannot happen until they have passed. So framing sits behind a queue you do not control, at an office your building department has no relationship with. **Book the state rough inspections as early as the work allows**, get the certificates in hand, and bring copies to framing. Every week lost here is lost twice, because the trades cannot close up until framing passes.

WHAT "FINISHED" MEANS WHERE YOU ARE BUILDING

If your jurisdiction issues a certificate of occupancy, that is the finish line and it will want the trade certificates first. If it has no building code there is no CO, and the documents below are what a lender, insurer, or future buyer will ask for instead. Collect them either way.

- ☐ **Certificate of approval — electrical**, from the state or local inspector. On the electrical side this is also what evidences that the work was inspected, the condition your homeowner exemption depends on (12-115-116(2)).
- ☐ **Certificate of approval — plumbing, and gas piping if separate** — plus the **utility's final approval and permanent meter set**, which the board's notice to the utility releases (12-115-120(1)(b), (c)).
- ☐ **OWTS final inspection and any as-built** your public health agency requires — the system may not be used before it passes — and the **well permit, well construction report, and pump installation report** as filed with the Division of Water Resources.
- ☐ **The energy certificate posted in the house.** Under the 2021 IECC as adopted by Colorado jurisdictions, a permanent certificate of insulation R-values, window U-factors, and equipment efficiencies is completed by the builder and posted near the furnace or another approved interior location. As owner-builder, you are the builder.
- ☐ **Certificate of occupancy**, if your jurisdiction issues one.

INSPECTION LOG

Record every inspection as it happens — nobody else keeps this record

Inspection	Authority	Called	Held	Result	Corrections required / notes
Footing / setback					
Foundation wall					
Underground plumbing / slab					
Rough electrical					
Rough plumbing / gas					
Rough mechanical / framing					
Insulation / air sealing / drywall					
Final — electrical					
Final — plumbing / gas					

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Inspection	Authority	Called	Held	Result	Corrections required / notes
OWTS final					
Final — building / CO					

Electrical inspector: _____ Plumbing inspector: _____ Building inspector: _____

Utility released: _____ OWTS accepted: _____ CO issued: _____

Sources — every Colorado claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
State inspector must inspect within three working days of the application	C.R.S. 12-115-120(2)(b); 12-155-120(1)(b)
Certificate of approval issued on a passing inspection	C.R.S. 12-115-120(3)(a); 12-155-120(2)(a)
Written notice of disapproval with reasons; posted at the site; reinspection fee; appeal heard within seven days	C.R.S. 12-115-120(3)(b), (4); 12-155-120(2)(b)
Board notifies the utility; no service without proof of final approval	C.R.S. 12-115-120(1)(b), (1)(c)
OWTS final inspection before the system is placed in use	C.R.S. 25-10-106(1)(h)
Do not call the Division to schedule — contact your inspector; inspector lists and maps published; presence policy for occupied dwellings; remote video waiver	DPO permits page, dpo.colorado.gov
Engineered soils report and stamped foundation plans; published design criteria; multi-agency project approval routing	Colorado building-department checklists (see CO.2)
Permanent energy certificate posted at the furnace or approved interior location	2021 IECC R401.3, as locally adopted

Read any C.R.S. section cited above at leg.colorado.gov → Laws → Colorado Revised Statutes, which serves the official titles as PDFs. Read any rule cited as a **CCR** number — the State Electrical Board's rules are 3 CCR 710-1, the State Plumbing Board's are 3 CCR 720-1 — in the Code of Colorado Regulations at sos.state.co.us/CCR, where the PDF is the official version and every past version is listed with its effective date. Beware third-party statute mirrors: they lag the session laws, and Colorado renumbered its entire professions title in 2019, so older guides cite sections that no longer exist. All statute and rule text in this kit verified August 2026.